



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-168
FIRST IN COUNCIL
September 14, 2026

MAYOR SIDDIQUI
VICE MAYOR AZEEM
COUNCILLOR NOLAN

- WHEREAS: Small and locally owned businesses are essential to Cambridge's economy, commercial districts, and community life, yet opening or expanding a business often requires navigating multiple City departments, permits, licenses, inspections, and approvals; and
- WHEREAS: In 2021, the City conducted a Small Business Permitting & Licensing Efficiency Review, which found that lack of accessible information, complex regulatory requirements, and siloed departmental processes were major challenges for applicants, and recommended improvements including interdepartmental “one-stop” meetings, clearer guides and checklists, better online information, and establishing a Small Business Liaison; and
- WHEREAS: The City's 2022 BIPOC-Owned Businesses Survey further demonstrated the importance of these issues, with a third of respondents identifying assistance with permitting, zoning, licensing, and regulatory issues as a need that would make it easier to open a business, making it one of the four most frequently identified needs; and
- WHEREAS: The City is currently undertaking significant improvements to the residential permitting – simplifying requirements, streamlining reviews, enhancing interdepartmental coordination, and providing clearer information – and many of the same challenges, including unclear or duplicative requirements, inconsistent processes, and difficulty understanding the sequence of approvals, similarly affect entrepreneurs and small business owners; and
- WHEREAS: These challenges can be particularly burdensome for first-time business owners, small businesses with limited staff or resources, and entrepreneurs who may not have professional consultants to help navigate City processes; and
- WHEREAS: The City of Cambridge should strive to provide a permitting and licensing experience that is accessible, efficient, transparent, and easy to navigate while upholding essential standards for public safety, accessibility, sustainability, and consumer protection; now therefore be it
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to work with the Community Development Department, Inspectional Services Department, License Commission, Fire Department, Department of Public Works, and other relevant departments to develop a coordinated initiative to improve and streamline the permitting and

licensing process for small businesses; and be it further

ORDERED: That this work build upon the findings and recommendations of the 2021 Small Business Permitting & Licensing Efficiency Review and the 2022 BIPOC-Owned Businesses Survey, including identifying which recommendations have been implemented, which remain outstanding, and which should be updated or expanded based on current conditions; and be it further

ORDERED: That this work include engagement with small business owners, entrepreneurs, business associations – including those representing BIPOC-owned and other historically underserved businesses – and other stakeholders to identify the most significant barriers encountered when opening, expanding, renovating, or changing the use of a business in Cambridge; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City review the full small business permitting journey, from an entrepreneur's initial inquiry through permits, licenses, inspections, and opening, to identify opportunities to:

- create a clear, centralized guide or online portal outlining required permits, licenses, approvals, costs, expected timelines, and responsible departments;
- provide applicants with a roadmap or checklist tailored to business type and proposed activity;
- improve coordination and sequencing among departments so that reviews can occur concurrently when appropriate and applicants receive consistent guidance;
- establish a clear point of contact or coordinated "one-stop" assistance for applicants requiring approvals from multiple departments;
- simplify forms, eliminate unnecessary or duplicative requirements, and move remaining applications and processes online where appropriate;
- identify significant regulatory, zoning, building, accessibility, or infrastructure issues earlier in the process that could prevent or substantially delay a business opening;
- establish clearer service standards and expected review timelines and provide applicants greater visibility into the status of pending applications;
- expand pre-application assistance and technical support, particularly for first-time entrepreneurs, BIPOC-owned businesses, and small businesses without professional permitting expertise;
- explore appropriate uses of technology, including AI-assisted tools, to help businesses understand requirements and navigate City processes; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City evaluate opportunities to establish measurable performance indicators for the small business permitting process, including time to first review, overall processing time, frequency of incomplete applications or requests for additional information, number of departmental handoffs, and applicant satisfaction; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to report back to the City Council with findings, an assessment of the status of recommendations from the 2021 Small Business Permitting & Licensing Efficiency Review, recommended near-term and longer-term improvements, proposed performance measures, and any ordinance, regulatory, staffing, or budgetary changes needed to create a more transparent,

predictable, coordinated, and customer-centered small business permitting process.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

A handwritten signature in cursive script, appearing to read "Paula M. Crane".

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

That the City Manager is requested to work with relevant departments to develop a coordinated initiative to improve and streamline the permitting and licensing process for small businesses.